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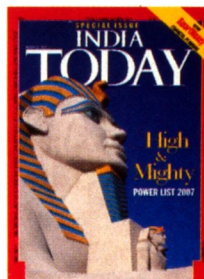
In his classic novel *1984*, George Orwell wrote about "the intoxication of power, constantly increasing and constantly growing subtler". This is the sixth year of INDIA TODAY's annual Power List and each year it is more challenging to identify the 50 individuals who wield the most influence on our lives. Power is difficult to define. There is power which stems from transient official positions—presidents, prime ministers, ministers, leaders of political parties or bureaucrats. That is why we do not include them in our list. There is also money power but wealth alone does not guarantee power. It is the position wealth may give and how it is used to affect society that matters. We select individuals based on their ability to extend influence on a national level beyond their regular work, those who are listened to, those who cannot be ignored, those who can bend the rules, those who are admired and become role models for others.

The definition of power is also influenced by developments in the country and, in the last few years, the most discernible change has been the dramatic rise of corporate India. They now rank regularly on global lists of the richest, most admired or among the best CEOs. That explains why half of the people on this year's list are industrialists, businessmen or executives, the highest yet. Within business it matters which industries are the new trailblazers. A few years ago it was infotech and later telecommunication, this year it is the infrastructure, real estate and financial sectors. The Indian obsession with celebrities also means that there is a strong presence of actors, filmmakers and sportspersons. Equally significant, if regrettable, is that the number of women on the list has come down quite dramatically, from eight in 2006 and seven last year to just four this time.

There are other subtle changes that reflect the pace at which India is moving, socially and economically. No less than 16 individuals who featured last year have been replaced by others, while intellectual-technocrats like former President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam and Delhi Metro builder E. Sreedharan have been given their rightful due. The changing times are reflected in our addendum to the Power List, which we introduced two years ago to track the change in power equations in an era of coalition politics.

The official list has the country's 10 most powerful people, politicians or government officials, and this year no less than four names are new. As regional parties and regional leaders rise to the forefront—Mayawati and Narendra Modi are prime examples—they are proving that a cleverly constructed agenda or sheer weight of performance has a national resonance. Indeed, the message is that official titles do not necessarily reflect the influence they wield. Overall, our 2008 power list reveals a changing reality: that vision, enterprise, performance, credibility and thinking out of the box are the attributes that matter the most. For a country in the grip of rapid change, that's great news.

*Aroon Purie*  
(Aroon Purie)



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